the disaffection of the local populace. Banerjee even went on a twenty-five-day fast in December 2006 against the land acquisition proposal.

Ratan tried pacifying the people by reaching out to them directly through an open letter. On 13 February 2007, he made this suggestion in a letter to Bhattacharjee and sought his advice. He also enclosed a draft of the letter he proposed to send. Soon thereafter, nearly a year after announcing the project, the Tatas and the state government formally inked the Singur land lease deal in March 2007.

Perhaps the company had failed to do a comprehensive feasibility study before finalizing the site. In a highly political state, no major land acquisition would be successful without the cooperation of the landowners. The situation was aggravated as a sizeable portion of the land was taken forcibly from unwilling farmers.

Tata Motors proceeded with the construction of the plant without assuaging the agitated farmers. It was a grave mistake. What followed were days of agitation filled with blockades, sit-ins and aggressive pushback by the police force. As the *Financial Times* wrote, '… the group may have made a costly mistake by basing the project in West Bengal'.

The chairman also saw another angle to the whole issue. 'It is not just political, because I happen to know that some of our competitors are also fuelling some of this fire … they would be very happy if the project got delayed,' he said in an interview to an Indian news channel. But that did not take away from the fact that the Tatas might have failed to undertake a due diligence study before finalizing the location.

Besides the political aspect, the suitability of the area for establishing a car factory should have got greater attention. The land was low-lying and vulnerable to flooding. The fact that it was situated at a considerably lower level than the highway should have rung a warning bell. The surveyors had even ignored Ratan who had queried, 'Why is there a level difference between the road and the land?' recalls Wagh.

The company would pay dearly for this oversight. Within about six months of the Tatas getting the lease, in September 2007, when the Damodar Valley Corporation (DVC), a hydroelectric project, released water into the area, it got flooded and the site went under seven and a half feet of water. There was virtual panic in the team. It called for the immediate redesigning of the assembly plant, which set back the project by weeks. The plinth levels of the buildings had to be redesigned. The alternate